

University Mark II

April 24th, 2011

University Peak, Onion Valley, CA

Full Pictures: <http://www.flickr.com/photos/matthewhengst/sets/72157626453391961/>

Last year I'd been up at Onion Valley for a one day Sierra Club snow workshop and decided to climb University Peak the following day. I threw together a private group and we set off.

Then the weather went from this...



...to this...



...in a few short hours. (Best video ever of the conditions at <http://www.flickr.com/photos/matthewhengst/4596963629/>)

This year I decided to try again. After all, what are the chances of having the exact same thing happen two years in a row...



... goddamnit.

Anyway, Saturday was spent pleasantly enough taking part in another excellent Sierra Club snow checkoff put on by Nile Sorenson and the all but legendary Doug Mantle.







Some folks drove up for the day and went home that night but a few stalwart (or foolhardy) folks were interested in hanging around for Sunday and climbing a peak. I had a grudge against University (see above) so off we went.

We slept out in Alabama Hills Saturday night which is always pleasant. That meant we had a bit of a drive in the morning so I kicked everyone out of their sleeping bags at 3:45 am.



Can you taste the enthusiasm?



We started roughly on time under clear if cold skies.



It was cold enough that even with vapor barriers my toes were cold in my leather boots for the first few hours but it meant we really didn't need the snowshoes we had along. Most of us wore them anyway for the extra traction provided during the climb to Robinson Lake.





We had a few clouds in the morning but then it cleared and the sun even made an appearance. Feeling started to come back to frozen toes. Life was joyous.



We reached the bowl below University Pass and angled towards the chute I'd climbed last year. This involved traversing a bit of a slope.



The snow was an annoying mix of ankle deep slough and ice. We made it maybe $\frac{3}{4}$ of the way to the chute only needing to cut occasional steps before we hit an extended icy patch and decided it was best to put on crampons.

This was an interesting maneuver which involved everyone whacking out small platforms, anchoring with their axes, and gingerly strapping on the spikes.



Much better!



We arrived at some bare rocks below the chute and took a break. At this point we were seeing a few wispy clouds coming over the ridge and Lisa and I, both veterans of last year, made a few jokes about the weather turning again.

As we started up the chute proper the clouds increased.





We were breaking through fluff past our knees the entire way. Fortunately we had the mighty Jen Blackie to blaze a trail.



We made the ledge at 13,200' which was the turnaround point last year. Once again we had high winds and the entire ridge was buried in clouds. But, other than that everyone was doing pretty well so we pushed on.

The following section was slightly unpleasant.





Once we came around the corner from the protected ledge we were battered by high winds from both sides. It was breaking chunks of ice off the rocks, smacking us with them in one direction, only to reverse and hit us from the other side. We had to use our hands to shield the small amounts of exposed skin as best we could as we stumbled on.



Once or twice we were hit hard enough we had to hunker down and hold on to our axes.



I even had snow blowing under my glacier glasses and freezing on my face which improved my mood greatly.

Jen and I were in the front scouting at best we could. We alternated between snow patches and climbing over rocks with our spikes.



We made it a few hundred feet down the ridge before we reached a particularly nasty spot. After a short ridge we had to cross a rock slab covered by loose snow followed by an awkward rock move around a corner.

Jen and I went past it but it was sketchy enough I didn't feel comfortable taking the group across.

We scouted a bit further but I had almost no visibility. I left Jen in contact with the group and pushed forward only to find myself on a steep snow slope above a rather fatal looking drop with almost no visibility.



Again, a video <http://www.flickr.com/photos/matthewhengst/5653691908/in/set-72157626453391961/>

Reluctantly I made the call to turn back. We had to be very near the summit but I couldn't see a thing and the risk of pushing on was too great. I wasn't about to leave most of the group sitting behind in those conditions.

Jen and I signaled the group to turn back and carefully picked our way back to the ledge.

It was slightly cold...





The return was uneventful outside of a few exposed spots where we had to descend. It's generally much more comforting \going up as you don't have to look at the big drop when it's behind you.



Once we were back to the ledge it was just a matter of descending the chute. The cold had iced up the snow but we were able to walk down unlike last year where we had to descend a very long way in the stake position.

I had hopes for glissading after breaking through all that powder on the way up but with the temperature dropping it was icing up.





We did manage some rather crappy glissades but had to really watch the icy patches that cause you to speed up suddenly and rough spots that banged the hell out of you.



We dropped further into the bowl instead of retracing our traverse and continued down towards Robinson Lake.

It did warm up quite a bit as we dropped elevation and we were able to get a few decent if short glissades in down there. Certainly better than last year where we had to walk out the entire way.

Everyone made it back to the trailhead in one piece. So University is still a grudge peak but at least we had an interesting climb.

Maybe next year. After all, what are the chances of the exact same thing happening 3 years in a row?

